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The quest for order among Awlad Ali of the Western Desert of Egypt

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CHAPTER V MARRIAGE: A CONTRACTUAL RELATIONSHIP

The contractual nature of marriage is most clearly manifested in the case of the wife's adultery. Since the woman belongs to her agnatic group, her behavior has direct effect on the honor of that group. It is, therefore, the responsibility of her closest kin to keep an eye on her. If the woman commits adultery, it is her father or her male kin who is supposed to avenge the honor of the family by taking drastic actions, including killing, against the adulteress and/or her partner. But the marriage usually takes the woman away from the close watch of her family and puts her under the supervision of her husband who becomes entrusted with the duty of guarding her, and therefore partially responsible for her action. His responsibility is enhanced by the fact that although the wife's behavior does not affect him or his family, it has a definite effect on the honor and reputation of his children (Abou-Zeid, 1965).

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The gravest insult that one can direct to a person in the area is to describe his mother of being of disrepute. In their joking relations, young men usually refer to each other's father as being a dog or a thief or a cheat, but none could refer to the mother. A woman of questionable reputation affects the reputation of her family in general and her children in particular. Any reference to the mother in the form of an accusation is supposed to be cleaned only by blood. Not only does this apply to the woman's voluntary behavior, but also to her physical and mental condition. If a woman loses her mind, the news is usually kept a secret, especially by her children. The responsibility for retaliation in the case of adultery, then, is divided between her nearest kinsman and her husband. This gives both sides a vague and undetermined right of revenge. This division of the right of revenge explains the infrequency  131 of drastic actions taken in cases of adultery. Of the fourteen cases of adultery that I

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examined during my field work, none resulted in the killing of the adulteress, and only three resulted in the murder of her partner. In all three cases where the adulterer was killed, the avenger was the husband; and in all three cases, the husband had to pay the bloodmoney to the murdered man's kin group. His payment of the bloodmoney, among other things, may indicate that the right of the husband to kill the adulterer is not completely accepted among Awlad Ali. All agree, however, that such killings never result in blood feuds because of the shameful circumstances in which the victim dies.

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